

How Can I Be Reconciled to God?

The Bible describes the human journey away from God in terms of the ultimate adultery. The great divorce is between humanity and God due to our being enticed by another lover! Thinking that something or someone other than God could satisfy and complete us, we turn to them in turning away from God. If this is the ultimate cause for disunion with God, then it, of course, anticipates the ultimate solution in terms of reunion with God—let me explain on both counts.

To be sure, it is never that we reject God in the abstract per se, although we may think this is so in an intellectual way. It is that we have been enticed by the illusion of something else satisfying and completing us. It may be many good things—like marriage, a job, the desire to provide for my family such as to warrant wealth, prestige under the disguise of wanting to make a difference in the world—on and on it goes—there is nothing that is not capable of enticing us away from God and becoming our “lover.”

Another way the Bible describes this kind of spiritual “harlotry” or “adultery” is by the term “idolatry.” And as one person once said, we are all born with an inherent disposition to be “idol factories.” It always represents a turning away from God, our maker and sustainer of life, in order to be completed by something else—what is then a god of our own making. In almost every case of spiritual idolatry, there is a justifying principle that makes serving the idol a “noble” thing, even as there is a material aspect that enables us to manipulate and control it in order to make it work for our interest. For example, if making money is the material aspect of idolatry (materialism), then a justifying principle could be the desire to provide for my family (familism). Again, this pattern can apply to just about anything. For instance, most marriage problems that I encounter stem from marriage idolatry—where a couple expects too much of marriage, not too little, as if marriage can complete us rather than God! Something intended to be beautiful and good as an opportunity for *ministry* turns sour because as an idol; marriages are perverted into opportunities for *manipulation* and an expression of self-love really. This results in guilt and shame, with then an endless cycle of defensiveness and blame shifting as a means of finding relief. Truly, in the words of the prophet Hosea, we create “idols of our own destruction” (Hosea 8:4) apropos

Anything and everything can be an idol. G. K. Chesterton once said, “When we cease to believe in God, we don’t believe in nothing, we believe in everything!” All of this “idol making” is of course a violation of even the first commandment since we worship things that are not really gods, as if gods (*cf. Ex.20:5*). But we do this only to our own demise and, ironically, the demise of the things we idolize.

And so what is the solution? We need a mediator, someone who can represent both marriage partners (humanity and God), as to insure that both interests are satisfied, even while reconciling God to humanity. Paul said it well, “Who will set me free from this body of death (condemnation)? His answer, “Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!” (Rom.7:19-20) Why Jesus? Because Jesus is both God and

human, one “person” and “two natures” in order to perfectly mediate the reunion of humanity to God! Paul later would explain that “there is also one *mediator* between God and humankind, Christ Jesus, himself human” (2Tim. 2:5). Yes, this was a miracle, even as the maker of heaven and earth is capable of such a miracle! What did Jesus have to do exactly? He took our place and satisfied all of the legal demands, both in the positive sense of worshipping God perfectly in a life of perfect obedience, and in the negative sense of satisfying God’s just punishment against sin completely, once and for all. God’s justice is satisfied while at the same time humanity is represented.

In order for us to participate in the mediation of Christ, we must first recognize the inability of our “idol” or “false lover” to satisfy us, even as we need to be reconciled to our true lover and God through Christ. We turn away from trusting in our idols and the confidence we place in ourselves to “work them” and turn to God by faith in Christ. When we receive Christ, all his work on our behalf is credited to us. It is as Jesus once prayed, “This is eternal life, that they may know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent.” (John 17:2) In the words of John, “to all who received him, who believed in his name, he gave power to become children of God, who were born, not of blood or of the will of the flesh or of the will of man, but of God.” (Jn.1:12-13)

And let’s be absolutely clear at this point. If you want to be reconciled to God and have eternal life, the thing not to do is say, “Okay God, I will try to do better, with your help in order for you to satisfy my restless heart with eternal life.” Again, this is only to create yet another idol called “moralism.” Rather, we place our confidence in Christ, His work and accomplishments, and ask God to give us the free, unmerited gifts of eternal life that have been earned for us by Christ and received by us through faith alone! He is alone qualified by his very essence to be the only mediator between God and humanity (1Tim.2:5).

Once we decided to “turn away from and returned” (what the Bible describes as repentance and faith), the way we do this is by uniting ourselves to Christ through uniting ourselves to the body of Christ, the church. To know more about this, see “should I join a church?”

Prayer:

God, I now see that I am more broken and sinful than I ever dared think in my idolatry, but more loved and accepted in Christ than I ever dreamed possible as revealed in Jesus Christ! I confess my sin of rebellion and my inclination to make idols. With your help, I desire to turn away from trusting in anything else save Jesus Christ in order to relate to you and to have life eternal. Please credit to me Christ’s life and death, and thank you for Christ, and the free gift of real life in him!